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WORLD CUP

Türkiye fans flock to Santa Clara to watch team play in World Cup match

By **Robert Handa** • Published June 19, 2026 • Updated on June 19, 2026 at 7:03 pm

Thousands of Turkish Americans gathered in Santa Clara Friday to cheer on Türkiye in its World Cup match against Paraguay at San Francisco Bay Area Stadium. Robert Handa reports.

Thousands of Turkish Americans gathered in Santa Clara Friday to cheer on Türkiye in its World Cup match against Paraguay at San Francisco Bay Area Stadium.

The Turkish American fans who showed up in the South Bay didn't just come from around the Bay Area. They traveled from all over the world.

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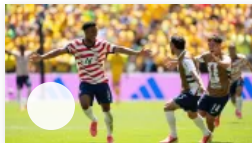
"I met Turks from Australia, from Europe, from Asia, from Canada," Ergun Kirlikovli of Los Angeles said. "Of course we're like long lost brothers. We hug, we kiss, and we say where are you from and all that."

One of the prominent Turkish Americans on scene in Santa Clara was Hamit Altintop, a soccer hero in Türkiye.

"All cultures, all communities, all generations are coming together and we are speaking only for one month just about fútbol," he said. "This is insane."

The gathering near San Francisco Bay Area Stadium was just one of many events taking place Friday. The Ataturk cultural house in Mountain View, run by the Turkish American Association of California, will serve as another major gathering place throughout the tournament.

"The World Cup means that we are one," Turkish American Association President Nalan Ozisik said. "No matter what we think politically, how we observe our various religious beliefs or what our ethnicity is, none of that matters anymore. This is World Cup and Türkiye is there after 24 years. That's all that matters today."



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